Treasure in Clay Jars

2 Corinthians 4:7-18 (KJV)

Scripture

2 Corinthians 4:7-18

[7] But we have this treasure in earthen vessels, that the excellency of the power may be of God, and not of us. [8] We are troubled on every side, yet not distressed; we are perplexed, but not in despair; [9] Persecuted, but not forsaken; cast down, but not destroyed; [10] Always bearing about in the body the dying of the Lord Jesus, that the life also of Jesus might be made manifest in our body. [11] For we which live are alway delivered unto death for Jesus' sake, that the life also of Jesus might be made manifest in our mortal flesh. [12] So then death worketh in us, but life in you. [13] We having the same spirit of faith, according as it is written, I believed, and therefore have I spoken; we also believe, and therefore speak; [14] Knowing that he which raised up the Lord Jesus shall raise up us also by Jesus, and shall present us with you. [15] For all things are for your sakes, that the abundant grace might through the thanksgiving of many redound to the glory of God. [16] For which cause we faint not; but though our outward man perish, yet the inward man is renewed day by day. [17] For our light affliction, which is but for a moment, worketh for us a far more exceeding and eternal weight of glory; [18] While we look not at the things which are seen, but at the things which are not seen: for the things which are seen are temporal; but the things which are not seen are eternal.

Outline

1. God puts his treasure in clay jars

We have this treasure in _____ vessels.

Our weakness shows that the power is of _____.

Read: 2 Corinthians 4:6-7; 2 Corinthians 12:9-10; 1 Corinthians 1:27

2. Pressed, but not crushed

Persecuted, but not _____.

Cast down, but not _____.

Read: 2 Corinthians 4:8-12; Hebrews 13:5; Psalm 34:19

3. Look at what is unseen and eternal

Though our outward man perish, the inward man is _____ day by day.

The things which are not seen are _____.

Read: 2 Corinthians 4:14-18; Romans 8:18; 1 Peter 1:6-7

Discussion questions

1. Why would God choose to put his treasure in fragile people instead of impressive ones?

2. Which of the four "but not" phrases in verses 8-9 speaks most to you, and why?

3. Paul calls his afflictions "light" and "but for a moment." How can he say that, given what he suffered?

4. What practical things help you "look at the things which are not seen" when life is hard?

This week

Memorize 2 Corinthians 4:16-18 this week. When a trouble presses on you, say the "but not" out loud: "Pressed, but not crushed." Reach out to one person in the church who is going through a hard time, and share this passage with them.